

Block

1

SOCIOLOGICAL THEORIES

UNIT 1**Cultivation Theory****7**

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COURSE INTRODUCTION: MEDIA AND COMMUNICATION THEORIES

Today scientific perspective has enriched the subject of Mass Communication. Theorists have contributed scholarship and literature to the understanding of the process of communication. Theory development has enabled us to understand the process of human communication and discover the relationship between mass media and human behaviour. The study of communication theories is the work of intellectuals that has given scholarly tradition to the discipline. The works of communication theories showcase the wisdom, scholarly discourse, classic narratives, and ideological debates of some of the best minds the world has seen.

The **Course MDC-006 Media and Communication Theories** is developed systematically and scientifically to enable you to gain core knowledge required for the discipline. This course is designed with the motto, that the study of Mass Communication is incomplete without the study of communication theories. It is planned methodically that takes you to all the areas of mass communication to get a scholarly experience for building your confidence and knowledge.

The course is presented in Four Blocks comprising 16 units covering all the topics relevant to the study of the subject. These blocks are interlinked and deal with specific topics. Some theories may find some reference in more than one unit which is a natural fallout of theory studies of media. Media is an integrated discipline that is studied from sociological, political, psychological, and cultural perspectives and the overlapping of some of the concepts is imminent to the broader understanding of the communication theories. It is advantageous for you as it helps you understand the challenging theories in a proper perspective and apply them in your research projects and day to day experience with media ranging from newspapers to social media.

Block 1 addresses the **Sociological Theories** in four units. Unit 1 introduces you to the nature and characteristics of cultivation theory. Unit 2 describes how media sets agenda in Agenda Setting theory; Unit 3 analyses what people do with media in Uses and Gratification theory. Unit 4 explains the integral relationship between audience and media in Dependency theory.

Block 2 has four units exploring **Psychological Theories** of mass communication. Unit 5 is about how people purposefully select messages that reinforce their pre-existing beliefs in Selectivity theories. Unit 6 deals with one more significant Individual Difference theory whereas Unit 7 concerns Persuasion and Attitude that is about the psychological process of persuasion and the role of media in it. Unit 8 deals with the Theories of Learning.

Block 3 focuses on **Critical and Cultural Theories**. The block assumes importance as it discusses some of the path breaking theories that influenced political system in both democracies and totalitarian regimes. Unit 9 discusses Marxist theories and Unit 10 gives you exposure to Critical theories where one learns about Frankfurt and Chicago Schools of Thought exposing you to some of the greatest political thoughts that enlightened the world. Unit 11 focuses on Cultural studies whereas Unit 12 deals with Political Economy theory which is a unique discourse on political system across the globe.

The final Block 4 of the course focuses on **Media-Society Theories**. Unit 13 introduces you to Technological Determinism that aims to analyse how media technology causes changes in social thought. In Unit 14 you study Habermas's classic theory of Media and Public Sphere and ponder over how public sphere works in present day society. Unit 15 deals with Audience theories and explains how the audience becomes a market. Unit 16 on Feminist Media Theories exposes you to various aspects of feminist research, stereotyping and gender positioning in media content.

Thus each Block gives you new knowledge dealing with the significant classic theories of Mass Communication and equips you with unique media experience. After completing this course, you should be able to:

- discuss the theories of media and communication;
- describe sociological theories to understand uses and benefits one derives from mass media;
- analyse the psychological theories to examine how communication works;
- explain the critical, cultural and gender studies theories that gives you knowledge about unique political thought and media; and
- apply all the theories in your project work, research and day to day life.

We hope you will find the course content useful in your work.



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BLOCK INTRODUCTION : SOCIOLOGICAL THEORIES

This is the first block of the Course **MDC-006: Media and Communication Theories**. There are four units in this block and each unit addresses major theoretical concepts related by broad sociological perspective.

Unit 1: Cultivation Theory introduces influence of television on viewers and cultural impact of media. It enables you to understand whether people are heavy, moderate or light viewers of television and how it navigates the life of heavy viewers. You can apply cultivation theory in your studies on media and violence and test some of the concepts given by George Gerbner.

Unit 2: Agenda Setting Theory describes the power of media and enables you to work on studies related to elections, and political issues. You can understand what are your own priorities of media issues and how do they correlate with what media shows. You can easily relate this theory to the shaping of public opinion on major issues.

Unit 3: Uses and Gratification Theory deals with what uses and benefits people derive from media. You will find answers for why people use media. You can apply this theory which was experimented with television as well as with new media and test the concepts of gratification people get, for example from using mobile phones.

Unit 4: Dependency Theory looks at how mass media have emerged as dominant players in modern society. It explains our degree of dependence on media and its profound influence on audience. You can apply this theory in studying audience-media-societal relationships in the context of new media.

It is advisable to study the units in a sequence as each one gives you new knowledge and prepares you for the mode of understanding subsequent units. All the units are tagged with common thread of sociological theories and hence make it easy to apply the concepts to your media experience. We hope that you will enjoy studying this Block and develop a good understanding of the concepts and perspectives discussed.



UNIT 1 CULTIVATION THEORY

Structure

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

This Block focuses on the Sociological theories of mass communication which include Cultivation theory, Agenda-setting theory, Uses and Gratification theory and Media Dependency theory. The sociological approach is based on the assumption that there is a definite relationship between mass communication and social change. Through the discussion we shall try to explore whether mass media cultivate common beliefs about the world or set an agenda for the people? Do media cultivate habits especially on people who are very dependent on it? Why do people use media and what their dependence on media does to them?

Among the theories, which focus on understanding the effect of media on its users, Cultivation theory has great importance. The theory is based on the assumption that mass media have subtle effects on audiences who unknowingly absorb the dominant messages, narratives and symbols of media. George Gerbner (1976) looked into the impact of television and explored how media can be influential in changing the behavioural patterns and cultural indicators in society.

He examined how individuals engage with media text and technologies in order to satisfy certain social needs.

In this unit, we shall study different aspects of Cultivation theory – the initial debates and the contribution of cultural theorists, the concept, nature, and significance of this theory and the implications of media usage on society. We shall also examine the strengths and limitations of cultivation theory and its application in research.

1.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the initial debates and core concepts of cultivation theory;
- describe the implications of media on users from the theorists' perspective;
- analyse the implications of media usage on the cultural index of society; and
- apply cultivation theory in your own research work.

1.2 INITIAL DEBATES

Communication has its association with culture since it creates, expresses, sustains, and alters cultural life. It also shapes our methods of communicating with others. Patterns of Communication that exist in society reflect on the cultural values and perspectives.

1.2.1 Cultural Theorists Contribution

The media-culture connection got its first great push from the Payne Fund studies in the 1920s and 1930s. The study considered an investigation of the influence of movies on young people. The researchers found that movies disrupted routine life of viewers such as sleep, moral values, emotions, attitudes, and behaviour (Stanley Baran and Dennis Davis, 1995). The public concern in the 1950s mainly focused on comic books, which were often called “funny books”. The comic books presented not only fanciful and humorous characters but increasingly violent and vengeful. These books were consumed by children with enthusiasm. To add to this; Gerald Stone, et.al (2003) also observed that the youngsters who owned a great stack of comic books exchanged and traded them among friends. Wilbur Schramm in his book Mass Communication (1960) explains that 70 per cent of the children in the age group of 9 was addicted to comic books by 1958 itself. We continue to see the popularity of comic shows on television that compete with movies and most of the parents and educators are deeply concerned about the negative role they play in a child's life.

By 1960s, the television advertisements for alcoholic beverages and tobacco products started bothering the government and researchers. Understanding the implications of the advertisements the television producers voluntarily withdrew such advertisements and replaced them with surrogate advertisements of the products belonging to the same company.

The cultural impact of media articulated by Melvin DeFleur (1960) shows that one way the mass media could influence behaviour was through the development

or manipulation of cultural norms. He observed that “the mass media, through selective presentations and the emphasis of certain themes, create impressions among their audiences that common cultural norms concerning the emphasised topics are structured or defined in some specific way” (Melvin L.DeFleur, 2016).

Post World War II, the United States was introduced to television and adoption of television as a new form of mass communication grew rapidly by 1950. The television introduced the viewers to motion pictures, audio-visual presentations, news, cartoons, documentaries, soap operas and others, all packed in one. The audience was naturally attracted towards this “medium as it provided cheap and easily available entertainment for American families who did not even have to leave their homes” (Melvin L.DeFleur, 2016).

TV viewing increased dramatically and within a decade almost all American households had a television set and attracted a huge audience towards it. Professor George Gerbner of Annenberg School of Communications at the University of Pennsylvania, developed Cultivation theory; sometimes also referred to as the cultivation hypothesis or cultivation analysis. He worked on a project to study how watching television may influence viewers’ ideas on what the everyday world looked like in the mid 1960s. The study ‘Cultural Indicators’ focused to understand the ‘effects’ of the programmes on the viewers.

1.2.2 Media and Violence: Mean World Syndrome

In almost all the surveys conducted by Gerbner, a significant relationship between TV consumption and fear about becoming a victim of the crime was revealed. To explain this phenomenon of long term effect on the viewers the term “Mean World Syndrome” was coined by George Gerbner. According to the fear Index developed by Gerbner, viewers who have high media consumption believe that the world is more dangerous than actually, it is and also television content has more violence in it. Gerbner and Larry Gross (1976) came out with a controversial violence index - an annual measure of the violence produced among the viewers. As explained by the theorists, violence was measured as “the overt expression of physical force (with or without a weapon, against self or others) compelling action against one’s will on pain of being hurt and /or killed or threatened to be so victimised as part of the plot”.

1.2.3 Perception of the Role of Media

Media has catered to programmes that give desired effects within the society and people living in that society. According to Maxwell and McCombs (2005) “media is not only successful in telling us what to think but they are stunningly successful in telling us what to think about”. Gerbner in his study observes “that heavy users of media believe that people are constantly involved with police for various crimes committed and they have a feeling of insecurity while walking also at night.

The Gerbner’s theory has two components, “the first is content of television about how the real world is constituted, and the second is frequent exposure to the distorted images in the content that results in their internalisation”. Griffin, in his study, finds that the viewers subscribe to statements that warn people to expect the worst and this mindset can be termed as the “mean world syndrome”.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is Mean World Syndrome?

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2) What are the two major components of Gerbner's theory?

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1.3 CORE CONCEPTS

A quick look at the television content shows that it is derived from multi-directional processes that involve society, the public, media institutions, and various interest groups. However, even with the assumption that all these propositions will remain valid, we still cannot answer the central question of whether television will continue to influence viewers' perceptions about the world and their cultural and social values. This perception is largely derived from the traits of television as a medium.

1.3.1 Significance of Cultivation Theory

Television offers a variety of thoughts and concepts to its viewers on social and cultural undercurrents related to society, for example race, gender, sexuality, etc. According to Gerbner, the main thing that people saw on television was violence and he was especially concerned that it "cultivated" the view among people that the world was a violent place. He defined it as "the overt expression of physical force (with or without a weapon), compelling action against one's will on pain of being hurt and/or killed or threatened to be so victimised, as part of the plot". People over a period of time use the programmes as a map to navigate life and the constant exposure to the media content cultivates specific values, beliefs, attitudes, and desires in people. As the dependency on television is increasing in today's world understanding of cultivation theory becomes more significant. The increasing dependency may be attributed to the nature of television, which is supposed to be helping viewers than any other medium to understand the intricate web of the norms, values, and mindset of the society.

1.3.2 Meaning and Nature

The theory suggests that media effects occur like the slow buildup of formations on cave floors, which take their interesting forms after the steady dripping of limewater from the cave ceilings. Gerbner and his team (1980) argue that "the media generally presents an image of the world that does not reflect reality". The media under study being television, the theorists observe that television images are an exaggeration or fantasy and are far away from reality. It argues

that viewers perceive the real world in a partisan manner and this perception of television holds good even today.

1.3.3 George Gerbner's Interpretation

Gerbner and his research team argued that the messages of television do not portray reality about the world. However, the beliefs about the surroundings or society are developed based on the repeated exposure and these beliefs get strengthened and the influence of portrayed messages cannot be neglected. Gerbner explaining the reasons about the influence of media on viewers finds the root in the art of storytelling. He observes "Humans are the only species that lives in a world erected by the stories we tell. The storytelling process used to be handcrafted, homemade, and community inspired. Now it is the result of a complex manufacturing and marketing process. The situation calls for a new diagnosis and a new prescription. That is what the Cultural Indicators and Cultivation research projects attempted to do". Gerbner observed the influence of television on viewers who watched it for a significant period of time on a particular day and found that those children who spent an average of four hours in front of the television got attracted to the stories, mostly sponsored by manufacturers of commercial products. This concern made Gerbner and his team work on the cultivation differential due to the constant penetration of constructed commercial messages.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Explain the significance of the cultivation theory.

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2) Write briefly on cultivation theory based on Gerbner's Interpretation.

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1.4 KEY THEORY

Television and many of the features of motion pictures - movement, sound, and visual representations, are just like films. However, the influence of television on its viewers is considered stronger as the medium also brought news, cartoons for children, soap operas, political campaigns along with films and film-based programmes. Since TV was packaged into one remarkable medium, which was positioned right in the middle of the American families, made the researchers think strongly about the influence of this medium. "People of America were struck to the cost-effective and easily available source of entertainment called

Television. As TV viewing increased dramatically, it did not take long for scholars to come to realise that its content was possible having a profound influence on the lives of Americans – and especially children” (DeFleur, 2016)

1.4.1 Conceptual Model and its Explanation

It is important to remember here that Gerbner’s theory argues about the influence of long persistent exposure to media, especially, television. The images created intentionally or unintentionally get compounded into solid construction. This phenomenon of construction of images which results in bringing a shift among the masses to accept television content as a socialising agent in the society is explained in the theory conceptualised by Gerbner. The perceived images start playing in the mind of the viewer based on his/her individual attention span, involvement, and the capacity of focusing.

The cultivation model argues that television viewing has its influence on heavy viewers, explains that a viewer who differs in their demographic characteristics can also differ in terms of their understanding towards social reality. As Gerbner and his team observed in their research, a viewer during the time spent in front of the television, is likely to live with the characters that appear on the small screen. Viewers are likely to believe in what is shown on television and accept it as actual social representation. Which then as identified by Gerbner indicates that “heavy viewers of television are likely to believe world created by television as a true representation of reality”. The views expressed on television dominates in the life of heavy viewers’ ability to understanding of beliefs towards social and cultural values. Here the assumption is, the more you watch television the more resemblance of portrayals of life in television thus influencing in accepting the reel world values and culture as real.

1.4.2 Social Reality

Gerbner’s approach has shown that television is related to images and conceptions of social reality held by children and adults in the areas of knowledge as geography, demography, personal and group stereotyping, age, sex, role expectations, crime, family life and so on. The cultivation hypothesis thus becomes testable in aspects of social ‘reality’. It is important to test the extent of influence of television drama in cultivating the reel conceptions towards society when the real-life stories are different.

1.4.3 Cultural Indicators

In contradiction to the earlier studies, the Cultural Indicators project by Gerbner and his fellow researchers was historically grounded, theoretically guided, and empirically supported. In the Cultural Indicators approach, Gerbner identifies a three-pronged research strategy – institutional analysis, message system analysis and cultivation analysis, as suggested below:

Institutional Analysis: The research conducted is designed to explore the formation and systematisation of policies related to the flow of media messages;

Message System Analysis: The research is designed to involve the methodical survey of week-long samples of television dramas that are being telecast. This will enable to check the content and trends that television presents to its viewers anywhere in the world.

Cultivation Analysis: The research here focuses on the analysis of social reality among the viewers but with a varying amount of exposure to television content.

1.4.4 Types of Viewers and Effects of Television on Users

The most general hypothesis of cultivation analysis, which is one of the media effects studies, is that those who spend more time viewing the programmes are expected to be “living” in the world of television. The viewers are likely to visualise the “real world” through the lens of television and accept the characters, concepts, values, images, portrayals, and ideologies as they are portrayed. Heavy viewers of television will have long term effects cultivating attitudes about what they saw on television. The more you watch the more your ideas are influenced and correspond with the television view is the essence of this theory. It suggests that television has a role to play in cultivating viewers’ perception of social reality.

Gerbner and his team place television viewers into the following three categories:

- “Light Viewers: Those who watch television less than 2 hours a day
- Medium Viewers: Those who watch television 2-4 hours a day
- Heavy viewers: Those who watch television for more than 4 hours a day”.

He argued that heavy viewers after watching television for more than four hours largely form opinions that are similar to the ones portrayed on television instead of what is being practised in real life. He believed that television virtually subdues other sources of information and ideas mainly among heavy viewers. Nielsen group in their studies categorise heavy viewers as those who watch television for more than 11 hours of the day. The heavy viewers according to them are susceptible to get influenced as they depend on television images while cultivating their perceptions of the real world.

A study conducted by Indiana University on the cultivation effects of a reality television show called Teen Mom on young girls found that the respondents who regularly watched this show on MTV had an impractical view regarding teen pregnancy. A study conducted on television serials by Nandini (2009) finds that the youth are disturbed and do not believe in the family members, and the television serials have a dribbling effect on the family relationship. Many more studies have been carried out to understand the effects of media in a long run.

Researchers have tried to examine the cultivation effects of other media formats on individuals. Some of the examples that could be mentioned here are playing games on mobile, watching web series etc. In recent history, one such effect that is being widely talked about is “Blue whale” video game. In ‘Blue Whale’ game, parents were warned by the authorities about the disturbing effect of the game on children and was termed as ‘suicide game’. The victims of the Blue Whale game who survived assassination attempt revealed how the game controls their mind and behaviour and therefore can be viewed as a case in point that could be analysed within the framework of cultivation analysis.

1.4.5 Limitations of Cultivation Theory

Cultivation analysis is criticised for its claims and there are arguments that the theory is not always useful in explaining the phenomenon in detail. Researchers argue that all the content presented in television do not highlight violence and thus small screen content cannot be targeted constantly as responsible for

cultivating the sense of violence among the viewers. Researchers have also criticised cultivation theory for overlooking the viewers' understanding ability. It is true that a viewer will perceive the message according to his/her mindset. This makes us think about people's understanding of reality. It can be argued that attention should be given to content that cultivates perceptions than giving attention to the amount of television viewing. While arriving at conclusions, theory cannot ignore the cognition abilities of the viewer which includes attention or thinking abilities. However, the theory argues that the influence depends on the frequency of viewing which reflects on the quantitative method of viewing and less on qualitative terms which includes perception, persuasion, and effect of the content on the viewers.

Arguments related to theory also revolve around the pre-existing characteristics of viewer who may choose to watch only certain genres of programmes for example, crime or violence. In addition to the television viewing pattern, other external factors such as parallel usage of an alternative medium, personal life experiences of the viewer and the environment of viewing, people who are with him/her at the time of viewing may also influence the viewer about the response. Other studies suggest that sometimes heavy viewing may not influence a person's social construction of behaviour or worldview. The viewers may also not interpret what they see on television as real, this makes it very difficult to prove a causal relationship exists between the viewer and the media. If the viewer is aware of what s/he watching is fiction, then the implications on the viewer could be different.

Activity-1

Select a popular fiction programme on television. Analyse the views expressed by those who have watched this programme from the framework of cultivation theory.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Explain how Gerbner conceptualises his model.

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2) What are the three-pronged research strategies identified by Gerbner?

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3) What are the three categories of viewers?

Cultivation Theory

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1.5 RELATED CONCEPTS

The widespread public concern regarding the violence due to the influence of television on its viewers led many researchers to work in the concerned area. Gerbner who had begun his study on Cultural Indicators was eager to extend his research, which earlier focused only on prime time and weekend daytime TV network programmes. In his extended work, Gerbner assessed and documented ways in which the content of television influenced viewers' conceptions of reality. The term Gerbner chose to describe his focus of research was "Cultivation Analysis".

1.5.1 Cultivation Analysis

Cultivation analysis is based on the idea that the views and behaviours of viewers are an important theoretical perspective. This is because cultivation analysis focuses its attention on viewers spending excess time viewing the television. As these viewers are expected to adopt and replicate what they have seen on television. The cultivation analysis primarily focuses on analysing the message, which is predominant, frequent and consistent. Since these messages are consistent and replicated in a majority of images and portrayals, the values that are projected out of such programmes are practically inexorable for regular viewers. Since television content largely reflects the historical, social, cultural, economic and political backgrounds of a country, Gerbner's argument about Cultivation analysis being suitable to multinational and cross-cultural comparative studies holds good.

1.5.2 Application of Cultivation Analysis in Research

We find the application of cultivation theory largely in the studies related to violence particularly due to television viewing and some researchers have supported the claim. McQuail (2007) observed, "The researchers have found that those who watch television more frequently, often display tendencies of being depressed and lonely apart from developing a sense of alienation and feelings of mistrust. The feeling that the world is a malicious place is predominantly observed in such viewers". Many researchers have worked to explain the impact of violent characters on children who in turn become violent. The researchers have also observed that exposure to violence on television strengthens the concept that violence is a natural response in situations like conflict. Over the years, the application of cultivation theory has found its niche in the studies on health, politics, religion, and gender studies etc.

1.5.3 Examples of Cultivation Analysis

The researchers believe that viewing increases the accessibility of information in memory i.e ease of recalling information from memory and the second is related to the audience- largely related to the memory, which observes judgments are constructed through heuristic processing. When people process heuristically, they do not carefully consider all information in memory before constructing their judgments. Based on this, five specific propositions can be formulated as given below:

Television as a medium of influence: The characteristics of television being audiovisual, cost-effective entertainment provider and enjoyed in the comfort of home are the prime reasons. The most important thing to note here is that even illiterate is able to comprehend the content that uses storytelling and engaging narratives to capture people's attention. "The repetitive pattern of television's mass-produced messages and images forms the mainstream of a common symbolic environment"(Gerbner, et.al).

Influence of Television on viewers: Gerbner and Gross observe that the "realities created by television are not based on real facts but on speculation". Since the television content has systematically adopted the art of storytelling the theory focuses its attention on a connection that exists between the concept of the story and its influence on the viewer in believing it.

Television's effects are limited: Television is undoubtedly a popular medium and it has become part of the lifestyle of people. The researcher thus feels irrespective of viewing pattern, the effect of television is consistent. As Gerbner explains in support of his observations, "just as an average temperature shift of a few degrees can lead to an ice age or the outcomes of elections can be determined by slight margins, so too can a relatively small but pervasive influence make a crucial difference. The size of an effect is far less critical than the direction of its steady contribution". It is, however, true that viewing television does not bring in a behavioural change, but viewing for more time will bring in a change in the cognitive sense of the viewer.

Activity-2

Watch any two serials telecast on television channels, understand their narrative methods, and compare the reality projected in the serials with a real-life situation.

1.5.4 Mainstreaming and Resonance

The concept that led to the basic idea that many people view television extensively and medium can generate a Magic Bullet effect led to further explanations. Gerbner explains 'Mainstreaming' which means the viewers belonging to different group develop a common outlook. Since the content becomes a major source from which the diverse population acquires common and shared understandings of culture and in this case, it is American culture. This idea is drawn from the older concept of 'Mass Society', and by using 'Mainstreaming' and 'Resonance' Gerbner explains how watching television makes people more and more alike.

Mainstreaming: Television's position in our house plays a predominantly important role in our society as it is considered as the primary channel of the

mainstream of our culture. Mainstream can be considered as the cultivation of common viewpoint and values due to persistent exposure to the television content. Gerbner and his team observed that “through the process of mainstreaming, television may have become the true ‘melting pot’ of the American people and increasingly of other countries around the globe”(Gerbner,1980).

Resonance: The second refinement to general cultivation theory is resonance. Gerbner (1980) explains resonance as an interaction between television viewing and life experience and define *resonance* ”as the similarity between everyday reality and television narratives”. Any fictional character presented in a stereotypical way, for example ideal women in the Indian context being subjected to domestic violence. Such stereotypically presented images provide an exaggerated perception of violence for those individuals who are heavy viewers.

Viewers who correspond to the instances of their life with what they view on television will be most affected. In a simple sense, if a viewer has experienced violence in his/her personal life, heavy viewing of television programmes which highlights victimisation may result as a ‘double dose’. “This cultivation could have a large effect on our society if these viewers insist on receiving more security from the government, their workplace, family, friends, etc” observes Gerbner (1980).

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is Cultivation Analysis?

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2) Write a brief note on Mainstreaming.

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3) Write a brief note on Resonance.

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1.6 LET US SUM UP

Cultivation theory developed by Professor George Gerbner is focused on the influence of television on the thinking and behaving ability of the viewer. According to this theory, a long and persistent exposure to television is capable of cultivating common beliefs about the world. Gerbner and his associates call it 'cultivation of dominant image pattern' and argue that the messages of television do not portray reality in society; repeated exposure to such messages leads to development of particular beliefs about the world and these beliefs get reinforced once they are developed.

Cultivation theory classifies viewers into three categories namely, light, medium and heavy. The effect of media content is obviously found among the heavy users of television who believe that the real world has similarities with the world created by television. The theory argues that watching television for a long time will induce a certain paradigm and violence in the world.

The theory looks at the effects into two levels. At the first level the viewer is made to believe that outside world is similar to the world that is shown on television, and at the second level, the content telecast on television influences on specific attitudes of viewers for example hatred or violence, injustice etc. Later, Gerbner revisited his theory and added two concepts: Mainstreaming and Resonance to explain how watching television makes people more and more alike thus cultivates viewers' perception of social reality.

1.7 FURTHER READINGS

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1.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) George Gerbner coined the term "Mean World Syndrome". The term indicates that television viewing has a long-term effect on its viewers. The impact scale may vary but it is collective, definite and significant. As a result, of over usage of media content, heavy viewers of television develop a belief that the world is a dangerous place than it actually is, thus creating a sense of anxiety among the viewers.

- 2) The two components of Gerbner's theory are: the world as it is portrayed on television programmes differs significantly from the real world and the frequent exposure to these distorted images results in internalisation of 'facts' as perpetuated by television.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Television offers a surplus of content on various social and cultural dynamics to its viewers. According to Gerbner, the main thing that people saw on television was violence and he was especially concerned that it cultivated the view among people that the world is a violent place.
- 2) Gerbner and his colleagues argued in cultivation theory that the messages of television do not portray reality about the world but the repeated exposure of individuals leads to the development of particular beliefs about the world and the beliefs get reinforced once they are developed. This effect could largely relate to the method adopted to narrate incidents. Storytelling is an art and television successfully incorporates in its content presentation and when stories are repeated viewers undoubtedly get influenced.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Gerbner's conceptual model argues that television viewing has its influence on heavy viewers. It explains that a viewer who differs in his demographic characteristics can also differ in terms of his understanding towards social reality. As Gerbner and his team observed in their research, a viewer during the time spent in front of the television, is likely to live with the characters that appear on the small screen. Viewers are likely to believe in what is shown on television and accept it as actual social representation.
- 2) In cultural indicators approach Gerbner identifies three-pronged research strategy:

Institutional Analysis: The research conducted here are designed to explore the formation and systematisation of policies related to the flow of media messages.

Message System Analysis: The research is designed to involve the methodical survey of week-long samples of television dramas that are telecast. This will enable to check the content and trends that television presents to its viewers anywhere in the world.

Cultivation Analysis: The research here focuses on the analysis of social reality among the viewers but with a varying amount of exposure to television content.

- 3) Television viewers are divided into three categories of heavy viewers, medium viewers and light viewers. Among the three types of viewers television is expected to have its severe impact on heavy viewers.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) Cultivation analysis is based on the idea that the views and behaviours of viewers are important for the theoretical framework of cultivation theory. The cultivation analysis primarily focuses on analysing the message, which

is predominant, frequent and consistent. Developed on the theoretical perspective of cultivation theory, cultivation analysis is ideally suited to multinational and cross-cultural comparative studies. This is because every country's television system reflects the historical, political, social, economic, and cultural contexts within which it has developed.

- 2) Mainstreaming can be considered as the cultivation of common viewpoint and values due to persistent exposure to the television content. Television occupies an important position as a source of information and is considered as the primary channel of the mainstream of our culture.
- 3) Resonance is an interaction between television viewing and life experience. Any fictional character presented in a stereotypical way provides an exaggerated perception of violence for those individuals who are heavy viewers.



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UNIT 2 AGENDA SETTING THEORY

Structure

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2.0 INTRODUCTION

Agenda-Setting theory discusses the power of media to set the significance and priorities of issues and events in the mind of the public. This theory maintains that the media are more successful in telling people ‘what to think about’ than in telling them ‘what to think’ and over a period of time the very priorities accorded by media to issues become the public priorities as well. The term Agenda-setting was coined by Maxwell McCombs and Donald L. Shaw (1968) in the context of election campaign where politicians seek to convince voters about the party’s most important issues. They assert that agenda-setting “function of the media causes the correlation between the media and public ordering of priorities” (McCombs and Shaw, 1968). Agenda-setting theory further explains the reason behind the trend that some issues are treated with policy actions while other issues are not. The Unit provides a necessary path to study the theory.

2.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit you should be able to:

- discuss the history and development of Agenda setting theory;

- describe the implications of media on users from the theorists' perspective; and
- analyse the implications of media on the consumers of media messages.

2.2 INITIAL DEBATES

Various research studies have revealed that news broadcast on media plays an important role in setting a nation's agenda and in concentrating public focus on a few vital issues. This theory claims that the characteristics of public matters which earned prominence in the media at a particular period of time turn out to be noticeable in public opinion. The power of media to set some persons, issues, and topics as the prominent of the time is called Agenda-setting of mass media. The concept of this theory can be traced back to US presidential election 1968, when Maxwell McCombs and Donald Shaw used it as an alternative theory to examine how media influence the opinion of the people, especially in election processes. Both of them were Professors at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and this case study of the 1968 US presidential election was later called the Chapel Hill studies which examined the link between the priority issues of the mass media and the priority issues of the public.

Even though communication scholars, Maxwell McCombs, and Donald Shaw are usually associated with the phrase "agenda-setting function of the mass media" there is evidence for Plato discussing the issue of Agenda in his classic work, *Republic*. We also see the efforts of Machiavelli (1513), Hobbes (1651), Rousseau (1762) and Lippmann (1920) who discussed the nature and influence of public opinion over the decisions. Bryce (1888) in his study on newspapers and Walter Lippmann, in the early 20th century, discussed the relationships among the press, its readers, their opinions and public policy.

2.2.1 Walter Lippmann: Theory of Public Opinion

Walter Lippmann, a pioneer in communication research unveiled the Agenda-setting function of mass media. He was an influential newspaper columnist and longtime American presidential advisor. Well known for his 1922 book, *Public Opinion* in which he argued that average people are not capable of taking important decisions as they cannot perceive the happenings of the world. He said that discrepancies exist between, "the world outside and the pictures in our heads". For example, information about government is given to us by a group of people that creates images in our mind and we make a public opinion on those issues that are given to us. Lippmann calls this 'pseudo-environment' and cites an example of how gusty winds break window glass pane and the girl who watches this incident believes that it has signalled the imminent death of a relative. Lippmann observes a superstitious belief can make a person think illogically as s/he will relate the incidence to his/her belief than judging situation using the help of an authentic messenger. Invariably, pseudo-environment creates public opinion than factual experience, and ordinary people are prone to be victims of this process, therefore learned technocrats should decide on public affairs than common people.

According to him "mass media are the principal connection between (a) events that occur in the world and (b) the images of these events create in our minds". (James W. Dearing & Everett M. Rogers, 1997). Lippmann (1920) compared an

ordinary man to a deaf viewer sitting in the back row and is ignorant of what is happening in front of him. “He lives in a world he cannot see, does not understand, and is unable to direct.”(D. Stanley J. Baran & Dennis K. Davis, 1999).

2.2.2 Maxwell McCombs and Donald Shaw

The term ‘Agenda-setting theory’ was further popularised by Maxwell McCombs and Donald Shaw. Once the findings of the Chapel Hill studies appeared in 1972 many other scholars continued research on various fields about the agenda-setting effects of mass media.

Based on Cohen’s (1963) idea that “the press may not be successful much of the time in telling people what to think, but it is stunningly successful in telling its readers what to think about”, McCombs and Shaw (1972) hypothesised that “the mass media set the agenda for each political campaign, influencing the salience of attitudes toward the political issues”. McCombs and Shaw, after relating the rank-ordered topics on the media agenda with the key topics of the day on the agenda of doubtful voters, came up to a conclusion that the media agenda was greatly correlated to that of the voters, thus gave proof of Agenda setting (i.e., first-level agenda setting). As a follow-up to the Chapel Hill study, Shaw and McCombs (1977) presented the idea of an attribute agenda in which they argued that not only the media agenda but also object attributes have an agenda-setting effect, illustrating the influence of the attribute agenda in the news on the public’s attribute agenda (i.e., second-level agenda setting).

2.2.3 Cognitive Effects of Mass Communication

The influence of the news media in setting the agenda is not limited to the initial step of focusing public attention on a specific subject. The media also influence our understanding and view of the subjects in the news. The aim is to focus the media and the public’s attention on a specific topic. In turn, each object has many attributes, and characteristics that describe the object. There is also an agenda of attributes because some attributes are emphasised when the media and the public think and talk about an object, others receive less attention and many receive no attention at all. For each of these issues, the agenda of attributes presented by public figures or other objects literally influence the images themselves that we consider. Pictures of political candidates and other public figures held by the public are the most obvious examples of the setting of the agenda by the news media (Maxwell McCombs, 1998).

2.2.4 Issue-Attention Cycle

From above discussion, it can be observed that through repetition media provides cues to the public as to the relative importance of an issue. The similarity in the amount of media coverage given to an issue creates a consensus about an issue’s priority on the public agenda. As the cumulative number of media messages about an issue increases over time, the public is persuaded to accept the importance of the issue. Slowly, the public agenda for an issue gathers importance and will melt away gradually (James W. Dearing & Everett M. Rogers, 1997). A news item draws public attention and sustains attention so drawn but it does not last long and public start losing interest in that issue after some time and both media and public demand new issues as it is no longer news for them. Media attention always keeps an issue alive but it is short-lived or long-term depends on public attention.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Write about Walter Lipmann Theory of Public Opinion.

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2) What were the main arguments of Maxwell McCombs and Donald Shaw?

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2.3 CORE CONCEPTS

Agenda-setting is the phenomenon of the mass media in picking and representing certain issues repeatedly and importantly. The chief concept in the agenda-setting theory is the transfer of the importance of issues or how media emphasis on certain issues raises their importance for the public. (Maxwell McCombs, 2004). The process of setting an agenda happens primarily on two levels.

First-level Agenda setting: Focus on the amount of coverage of an issue. It suggests that media is capable of deciding the list of issues that the public will be made aware of and it is media, which decides what the public should be made aware of.

Second-level Agenda setting: Focus on the influence of attribute salience, or the properties, qualities, and individualities that describe objects or people in the news. It also discusses the tone in which these qualities are attributed. The attributes of second-level Agenda setting can be further categorised into two sections: substantive and affective.

Substantive dimension focuses its attention towards issues like personality, ideology, and mapping of thoughts for a media house of a candidate. The mapping could also be on issues related to inflation, unemployment or something related to the economy. In simple words, mapping of the ideology of the subject with the mindset of the media house is expected here.

On the other hand, the affective dimension focuses on the emotional qualities. According to the mapping of substantive dimension, the tone of the presenter is set. For example, a tone can be set towards a candidate's leadership ability which could vary between positive to negative or remain neutral. "As in first-level research, second-level findings show that attributes of political candidates and issues emphasised in news coverage become the attributes emphasised by voters" (H. Denis Wu and Renita Coleman, 2014).

2.3.1 Significance

Media creates dominant pictures of public affairs among the public. Agenda-setting shows that media can prioritise news and make the public accept that priority. The theory is significant for mass media as it uses this to guide public attention, debate, and public interest. It helps media to give long life to selected news stories to increase its reach, circulation/viewership, which ultimately helps in the increase in advertising revenue. Agenda-setting also helps in raising the importance of an issue from a public point of view that shapes public policy, and political decision-making. The sustained media interest in issues of great public importance can have an agenda-setting effect leading to public participation in the political process in social, political, or economic issues. With information overflow due to the technological revolution, a larger population can now access media making Agenda- setting important and challenging.

2.3.2 Principles and Characteristics

A common finding of numerous agenda-setting studies dating back to the original study by McComb and Shaw is that at a given point, or over a certain period, different media play a similar salience on a set of issues. Real-world indicators are relatively unimportant in setting the media agenda. The agenda-setting process is one of social construction through which key individuals interpret clues from the media and from their environment to determine the salience of an issue. The position of an issue on the media agenda importantly determines that issue salience on the public agenda. When the media give heavy news coverage to an issue, the public usually responds according to the issue a higher salience on the public agenda. This relationship of the media agenda to the public agenda seems to hold under a wide variety of conditions, for a diversity of issues, and when explored with diverse research methods. (James W. Dearing & Everett M. Rogers, 1997)

Using social media platforms desired changes may be implemented in the society since social networking sites are tools for public communication and have lowered the barrier to access for users, changing the role of traditional gatekeepers. Users sometimes become producers of information, but more importantly, information producers lose the monopoly on their information. Some studies focusing on the Internet have demonstrated how different online platforms could become the source of media agenda. However, these studies were mostly analysing the relationships between blogs and the traditional media agenda. For example, studies have shown that bloggers have an impact on what journalists choose to write about (Messner & Distaso, 2008; Wallsten, 2007). But at some point, these bloggers are part of the same elite group as journalists, therefore the discovered effect is similar to the previously existing intermediary agenda-setting in traditional media (Meraz, 2009; Hindman, 2008).

Activity-1

Take any recent case that has received dominant media attention to set an agenda and suggest what sources you would need to assess the media agenda.

2.3.3 Gatekeeping

Gatekeeping is an editorial process of selecting news by controlling the flow of information from media to the public with an element of bias. As Lewin (1947) puts it, the concept of gatekeeping is by and large the ways in which information is circulated, or not circulated to the public. This filtering and selection of information consisted of the ‘gatekeepers’; elite newsroom producers and editors, selecting the stories that they deemed integral to their audience (White, 1950). Since scarcity played a large role in the collection of news, traditional media outlets were effectively given the power to direct the agenda of topics discussed among society (Scheufele & Tewksbury, 2007). By selecting the information to disseminate and the order in which such information would be delivered, traditional mass media outlets would create a perceived hierarchy of importance to the stories presented, that mass audiences subliminally ascribe to world events (McCombs & Shaw, 1972).

The gatekeepers of society play an important role and are in complete control of the information received by the public. The gatekeepers “are therefore also in control of how the public perceives the rest of society’s reaction to news stories” (Barzilai-Nahon, 2008). For example, the letters to the editor section of a newspaper, a section dedicated to voicing the views of the readers. All letters are submitted to the newspaper’s headquarters, where the gatekeepers are able to filter through submissions and select only those that benefit their objectives (Burns, 2008).

The technological revolution has exhibited a tremendous increase in the accessibility of the Internet among people, the dearth of information on issues which interest the public has largely been on the decline. According to Meraz, this abundance “has turned the table on the gatekeeping and agenda-setting effects of mass media on the public”. Furthermore, the researcher adds “with the creation of social media, user-generated content has empowered the public with the tools for becoming their own gatekeepers and agenda-setters of information”(Meraz, 2009). Today, traditional mass media outlets are just one part of the greater ecosystem of information disseminators and members of the audience play a role as ‘secondary gatekeepers’; individuals with an online following that are able to distribute information to an even smaller audience of people with similar interests to the so-called ‘secondary gatekeeper’.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What are the levels of influence under the Agenda setting Theory?

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2.4 KEY THEORY

Agenda-Setting is a conception that the media may be ‘unable to influence people what to think, but are quite adept at saying, people, what to think about’. The issues that the media cover become the issues that the public believes are important, including the subtopics among those issues. Several steps are reviewed in the agenda-setting research process: 1. The measure that issues are most important by the amount of coverage they receive in the news media, 2. Measure the public agenda of important issues with a survey, 3. Show that the media cause the public agenda, and 4. Assess agenda-setting implications.

2.4.1 Conceptual Model and its Explanation

Agenda- setting is a complex process in which media agenda, policy agenda and public agenda are involved and are interconnected with personal experience and interpersonal communication factors. On the other side, there are real-world indicators of the importance of an agenda issue. It is important to note that the agenda indicated here are area and time specific. The issues or agenda compete with other issues of the time to gain the attention of the media or people concerned who could be policy makers or the public. For example, if we take up the example of an increase in alcohol consumption among youth, the extent of consumption becomes important. Apart from the facts that are relevant, for media attention, the interest of the gatekeeper also plays an important role. The gatekeeper here could be the owner of the press or any person in authority who has the power of decision making such as the editor, reporter or even a marketing manager.

2.4.2 Agenda Setting Function of the Press

Agenda- setting can be explained as “media’s attempt to create and transfer salient issues into the public domain to enable the public to discuss, deliberate, or debate on the issues to make informed decisions”. The basic assumption of this theory is that the media over its production processes and gatekeeping roles adds importance to some socio-political issues while ignoring others of parallel importance. Malcolm McCombs and Donald Shaw argued that “the media makes certain political, economic, and social salient issues in the society and they may not be successful in telling people what to think, but it is stunningly successful in telling what to think about”. (Bernard Cohen, 1963). This is so because, the press (news media in general) selects any a number of issues, topics, and events from its continuous surveillance of the environment to process and report daily as ‘the news’. Secondly, due to its space and time constraints towards selecting “newsworthy,” many issues and topics can be ignored. Going by the

news value, the press assigns a particular position to the story, which is calculated in terms of time and space. Therefore, when the public reads/views today's news reports, they will perceive the order of prominence as assigned by the press (Melvin L. DeFleur, 2010).

2.4.3 Strengths and Limitations

The theory focuses its attention on two important things - the importance people give to the issue that matters to them and how media intends to treat that particular issue. Agenda-Setting theory being a dynamic theory provides explanations of the effects of media both at the macro and micro levels. The strengths of media Agenda-Setting are the power of predictions. When people are frequently exposed to the same media and similar content will probably make people accept opinions set by media. Each medium has its own style of presenting the story that will enable them to grab the attention of viewers. It is media, which aligns the topics and decides about prioritising the issue. Irrespective of the select stories being highlighted or not in the newspaper, television as a media offer the spectators a 'window' for viewing the world from their perspective.

Critics, however, argue that the evidence is insufficient to show a casual connection between various agendas of the media and the public (McQuail, 1983). Media may alter the awareness, priorities, and salience to the thoughts to which people are attached, but cannot form or hide problems. The decision making ability of the gatekeepers is also questioned and for people who have already taken a decision, the effect of media may be weak.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Explain the Conceptual Model of the Agenda Setting Theory.

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2) Discuss the strengths and limitations of the Agenda Setting Theory.

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2.5 RELATED CONCEPTS

Agenda-setting maintains that there is a strong correlation between the importance that mass media give on selected issues and the significance endorsed to these issues by mass audiences (McCombs & Shaw, 1972). The associated concepts of Agenda Setting are: Priming, Framing, and Public Opinion.

2.5.1 Priming, Framing, and Public Opinion

Priming is considered as an extension of agenda setting. This is on the grounds that decisions and frame of mind development are straightforwardly corresponded with “the ease in which instances or associations could be brought to mind and by making some issues more salient in people’s mind” (agenda setting), mass media can also form the considerations that people take into account when constructing judgments. For example: Decisions on Politicians. The process of priming does not unmistakably modify people feelings and convictions, but rather it can possibly impact the issues voters consider to be generally essential. Therefore, even when an issue is not of immediate concern, constant media attention given to the issue makes it an issue of prime importance. It enhances attention to an issue and influences people to decide on an issue of public importance. Largely, the Priming theory effect is seen more during elections as the public favour some issues and ignore others. Lead stories, breaking news, and such other news coverage create importance even for less important issues.

Framing is part of the agenda-setting tradition that places a news story within ‘a field of meaning’. Media adds frames to news to make people accept and understand it in the way it is intended. The psychological roots of framing based on the experimental study by Kahneman and Tversky (1979, 1984) and the sociological foundations of framing were laid by Goffman (1974). Framing, therefore, is both a macro level and a micro level construct (Scheufele, 1999). As a macro construct, “framing refers to modes of presentation that journalists and other communicators use to present information in a way that resonates with existing underlying schemas among their audience” (Shoemaker & Reese, 1996). In fact, framing, for them, is an essential tool to lessen the complication of an issue, given the restraints of their particular media related to news holes and airtime (Gans, 1979).

Public Opinion is another important aspect of agenda-setting theory. Public opinion existed even during ancient days and refers to the public voice on issues of public interest. It shows the conflict between public and government on some issues where winning public support becomes important. In a democracy, the public opinion prevails whether it is a price rise of commodities, environment, and communal issues. Public opinion is subject to the degree of independence enjoyed by the citizens, the rule of law, and the amount of public participation. According to agenda-setting theory, “the public perceives issues that receive the most media coverage to be those of greatest importance (McCombs and Shaw, 1972) and that will influence their opinion”. Research has proved that the public can organise concepts thematically and can retain only a limited number of considerations in their minds and when they are queried about issues or opinions, a response is generated.

Public opinion is also discussed in the context of the Spiral of Silence effect. It is a kind of third party opinion formation. It is a human tendency for us to think about what others think about an issue. Proposed by Elizabeth Noelle-Neumann (1974), it says that people with minority opinion refrain from expressing it in public for fear of reprisal, therefore, allowing majority opinion to prevail. The silence of minority never forms the public opinion of an issue as it is in opposition to the majority view. The minority remains silent because of the fear of negative implications in the public domain. However, with new media, people with an unpopular opinion are also daring to express their opinion in media but its influence is debatable and more research will reveal the “Spiral of Silence Effect” on public opinion in the context of new media.

2.5.2 Recent Developments

With the arrival of new communication technology, media has become a lot more customised and interactive. Even today, media has not lost its power to prioritise news and one can witness the importance of an issue either rises or falls depending on public attention drawn by the media. Griffin (2009) states, “The mass media have the ability to transfer the salience of issues on their news agenda to the public agenda”. According to McQuail (2000), the theory contributes to the shaping of public perception of political and social reality.

The theory is criticised that the agenda influences are marginal and temporary but this will not make such effects less significant. The theory continues to be central to political communication and relevant in the present context. Media priorities of news hardly change but the audience will seek news as per their personal agenda is the new narrative on agenda setting. Media is not only vested with the power to create awareness of public issues but is also capable of giving frames to public agenda.

Check Your Progress 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is Priming?

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2) What is Framing?

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3) What is Public Opinion?

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Activity-2

Take a recent election which was extensively covered by the mainstream media. Identify some predictions being made. Analyse if these predictions were later found correct or not.

2.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we examined various aspects related to the Agenda-Setting theory. We started with Walter Lippmann's Theory of Public Opinion who pioneered early thinking about agenda setting. He emphasised the role of mass media in shaping public opinion, eventually setting the research tradition on agenda-setting.

Maxwell McCombs and Donald L. Shaw (1968) found that the prominence of the news agenda was highly correlated to that of the voters, thus providing evidence of Agenda setting. They posited that the popular agenda of the media influence society and the agendas held by media are deemed to be important and the issues publicised by media gain importance among the public. Over a period of time, according to this theory, the very priorities accorded by media become the public priorities as well.

The concept of gatekeeping was discussed in the unit which involves filtering and selecting the information for the audience. These 'gate keepers' could be any person in authority having decision making ability in a media organisation such as editors, reporters among others.

We then examined the relative strengths and limitations of the theory and it was discussed that media has the power of predictions and when people are frequently exposed to the same media and similar content, it will probably make people accept opinions set by media. However, decision-making ability of the gatekeepers was considered a weakness of the theory. Media may alter the awareness, priorities, and salience to the thoughts to which people are attached but these influences are marginal and temporary. The new communication technology has led to audience fragmentation as they are accessing information from different devices and in different ways.

The concepts of priming, framing and public opinion were also discussed and it was argued that media is not only vested with the power to create awareness of public issues but is also capable of giving frames to public agenda. Thus despite limitations, the theory continues to be central to political communication and relevant in the present context.

2.7 FURTHER READINGS

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2.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Walter Lippmann was a scholar of propaganda and public opinion who pioneered early thinking about agenda-setting. He argued that the mass media are the principal connection between events that occur in the world and the images of these events in our heads. He emphasised the role of mass media in shaping public opinion, eventually setting the research tradition on agenda-setting.
- 2) McCombs and Shaw observed that the mass media set the agenda for each political campaign, influencing the salience of attitudes toward the political issues. By comparing the rank-ordered issues on the media agenda with the key issues of the day on the agenda of undecided voters, McCombs and Shaw found that “the prominence of the news agenda was highly correlated to that of the voters, thus providing evidence of Agenda-setting.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) The process of setting an agenda happens primarily on two levels. At the **First-level agenda-setting**, there will be a focus on the volume of reporting of an issue, telling that the media choose what issues the public will be informed of. **Second-level Agenda-setting:** Focus on the influence of attribute salience, or the properties, qualities, and individualities that describe objects or people in the news. It also discusses the tone in which these qualities are attributed. Amongst the two levels the attributes of second-level Agenda-setting can be further categorised into two sections: substantive and affective.
- 2) Gatekeeping is an editorial process of selecting news by controlling the flow of information from media to the public with an element of bias. This filtering and selection of information is done by gatekeepers who are newsroom producers and editors, selecting the stories that they deemed integral to their audience. The gatekeepers control information received by

the public and thus control how the public perceives the rest of society's reaction to news stories.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) Agenda-setting is a complex process in which media agenda, policy agenda and public agenda are involved and are interconnected with personal experience and interpersonal communication factors. On the other side, there are real-world indicators of the importance of an agenda issue or event. The issues or agendas compete with other issues of the time to gain the attention of the media or people concerned who could be policy makers or the public.
- 2) Agenda-Setting theory being a dynamic theory provides explanations of the effects of media both at the macro and micro levels. The strengths of the Media Agenda-Setting are the power of predictions. When people are frequently exposed to the same media; similar content will probably make people accept opinions set by media.

The decision-making ability of the gatekeepers can be a weakness of the theory. Media cannot create or conceal problems, however, media may alter the awareness, priorities, and salience to the thoughts to which people are attached. The effect is weakened with the people who have already taken a decision.

Check Your Progress 4

- 1) Priming is a social psychology concept used in political communication to judge politicians by public opinion. People favour or ignore some politicians based on the priming effect of media. Priming is the result of a prior context on the interpretation and retrieval of information. When news reporting of an issue gives that issue salience with the public, people may tend to favour a politician. Priming is assumed as an extension of agenda setting.
- 2) According to the concept of Framing, news is shaped in a new field of meaning by journalists and the public are expected to see news in that context. It means media selecting some aspects of an issue and put forward that aspect as the important one which will result in emphasising a particular cause of some phenomena. Media adds frames to news and expects the public to understand news in that perspective.
- 3) Public Opinion is a dominant opinion (not numerical) of informed public who are aware of the issue and form an opinion based on media effect. According to agenda-setting theory, the public perceives issues that receive the most media coverage to be those of greatest importance and that will influence their opinion.

UNIT 3 USES AND GRATIFICATION THEORY

Structure

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 - 3.2.2 Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs
 - 3.2.3 Mark Levy and Sven Windahl
 - 3.2.4 West and Turner
 - 3.2.5 Wilbur Schramm
- 3.3 Core Concepts
 - 3.3.1 "What do People do with Media?"
 - 3.3.2 Types of Uses and Gratifications
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- 3.4 Related Theories
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3.0 INTRODUCTION

The development of mass media has resulted in many new theories stressing the need to analyse the intricate relationship between mass media and society. Among them the two prominent theories are Uses and Gratification theory and Dependency Theory which have helped in transforming the perspective of Mass Communication. These theories discuss about usage of media and the stimulus or impulse behind it.

Two communication researchers Elihu Katz, and Jay Blumler (1974) developed Uses and Gratification theory as a reaction to traditional mass communication research which examined what 'the media do to the people'. Katz and Blumler shifted the attention to the media audience rather than media content and asked the question 'what people do with the media'. The 'uses' approach assumes that audiences are active and willingly expose themselves to media. The word 'gratification' refers to the rewards and satisfaction experienced by audiences after getting exposed to mass media.

In this unit we shall discuss the audience-centred approach of the Uses and Gratification theory which tries to explain how people actively seek out media to address their specific needs.

3.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through the unit, you should be able to:

- discuss why do people use media and what do they use them for;
 - describe the audience-centered approach of Uses and Gratification Theory;
 - explain why and how people actively seek out specific media to satisfy specific needs; and
 - apply this theory in your own work.
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3.2 INITIAL DEBATES

Media consumption has become so wide that many researchers have shown interest in doing studies on mass media. Many talks and discussions have taken place focusing on the choice of media, media consumption and media effects. Many communication researchers have propounded theories like hypodermic needle theory, Agenda setting theory, Dependency theory etc. Theories developed by Lasswell, Maslow, and Wilbur Schramm are closely related to UGT. In addition, Mark Levy & Sven Windahl and West & Turner have also shown interest in the UGT theory. Hence, we shall analyse a few of them in this section.

3.2.1 Harold Lasswell

Lasswell's model of communication is regarded as "one of the earliest and most influential linear communication models." The model was developed by American political scientist and communication theorist, Harold Lasswell in 1948 while he was a professor at Yale Law School. In his 1948 article "The Structure and Function of Communication in Society", Lasswell wrote: convenient way to describe an act of communication is to answer the following questions:

- Who
- Says What
- In Which Channel
- To Whom
- With What Effect?

In 1948, Lasswell introduced a four-functional interpretation of the media on a macro-sociological level. Media served the functions of surveillance, correlation, entertainment and cultural transmission for both society and individuals.

3.2.2 Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Abraham Maslow an educational scientist in the US put forward a theory called Maslow's hierarchy of needs. Later he included his observations on how people are curious to know many new things. In 1970 Abraham Maslow suggested that uses and gratifications theory was an extension of the 'Needs and Motivation Theory'.

His contention was that people try to satisfy their needs based on hierarchy. In his theory of hierarchy of needs, he organised the needs of the people in the form of a pyramid. When you climb down from the pyramid you go from less important to most important one. Self-actualisation placed at the top, as we descend the pyramid we come across ego/ self-respect, social/belonging, and security/safety. Biological/physical needs at the bottom of the pyramid is the largest and basic one.

3.2.3 Mark Levy and Sven Windahl

Deviating from Maslow's theory Mark Levy and Sven Windahl opined that UGT is an audience- centered theory. Here various forms of consumer activities are spread over audiences' exposure status and audiences' selectivity. It is interesting to learn that audience exposure status includes activity of the audience: before media exposure, during media exposure and after media exposure. The latter includes participation of audience and media usage. Many television viewers watch TV for the sake of watching it with no intention of getting any gratification. This kind of media watching is called binge watching. Thus, UGT theory cannot be applied to this kind of watching television programmes.

3.2.4 West and Turner

According to West and Turner, UGT has passed four developmental stages spread over four decades between 1940s – 70s and has been scientifically accepted. Communication researchers accepted this only after verifying those four stages or phases. The very first developmental stage took place in 1940s, and one could hardly find any deficit in the concepts and methodology. In 1940s there were only newspaper and radio media available for study, they had to concentrate on only these two media. They endorsed UGT as one of the most influential sociological theories that influenced methodology and new paradigm.

3.2.5 Wilbur Schramm

The famous formula 'Fraction of Selection' related to media was propounded by Wilbur Schramm, an eminent communication researcher and author. His formula 'Fraction of Selection' helped to determine which medium an individual might choose. The formula concentrated on the amount of gratification available from a medium and the amount of effort one has to exert. From this, the formula helps to conclude that amount of gratification an individual expects to gain from the medium is directly proportional to the efforts he has to make to seek gratification.

Check Your Progress 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Who developed Uses and Gratification Theory?

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2) What are the unique features of UGT?

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3) Explain 'Fraction of selection' formula.

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4) How UGT is viewed by other communication scientists?

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3.3 CORE CONCEPTS

As stated earlier, Elihu Katz, and Jay Blumler are credited for developing UGT in 1974, as a reaction to traditional mass communication research. Katz and Blumler shifted the attention to the media audience rather than media content. The unique feature of this theory is media audiences are active rather than passive. Besides receiving information, audience unconsciously make an attempt to grasp the sense of the message in their own context.

It is rooted in traditional mass communication research on how a specific media is sought and selected in order to provide their needs (Katz, Blumler, and Gurevitch, 1974 in Chiang, 2013). Till 1974 it was assumed that media audiences are passive but then Katz and Blumler gave a different direction to the traditionally believed view of passive audience. People seek specific media and content in order to satisfy their personal needs.

Uses and gratifications theory also explains what combination of attributes in media content lead to the satisfaction of the needs of audience. Different media offer a wide range of characteristic content (topics), modes of transmission (print or electronic media), and place of exposure (at residence or cybercafé) for the audience to interpret, thus, leading to a need for media to provide as much satisfaction to the public as possible.

UGT speaks about audience power — they can consume whatever media message they want and interpret and integrate the same into their own lives. In order to achieve satisfaction audience select the desired media to fulfill their interest. Hence, this theory contemplates, that media are pitched for or against information sources for audience satisfaction.

The sources of the media chosen are distinctive. As Jay Blumler points out in his book, “The Use of Mass Communication”, “Studies have shown that audience gratifications can be derived from at least three distinct sources: media content, exposure to the media per se, and social context that typifies the situation of exposure to different media.” It is clear that audiences spend time using the media in various ways. Whether they are killing time or using it as a social tool, each medium is unique in its purpose.

UGT theory can be studied under three different groups. The first group tests the range of gratification pursued from the media. The second group checks the social and environmental circumstances that make the people listen or view the mass media. The third group enquires the audience needs which attempts to satisfy them.

Types of Gratifications: As Gratification refers to satisfaction, receiving messages amount to gratification. Researchers have stated two different types of gratifications; “content gratification” and “process gratification”. In content gratification, receiving certain messages is more important, while in process gratification, participating in the “use process” is of much higher value (Windahl et al., 2008).

Models of Gratification: Different models of gratification have been presented in this theory. Denis McQuail has introduced two important models, the Cultural and the Cognitive models. Cultural model speaks about the usage of media solely because one feels dependent and belonging, whereas Cognitive model underlines that one may not be willing to use and listen to the message portrayed by that particular media.

Components of uses and gratification model: There are two components in the uses and gratification model;

- Gratification sought (GS) and
- Gratification obtained (GO).

These two components differ with respect to the concept and applicability, and neglecting their difference leads to misconception and misinterpretation of the results. When measuring the difference between these two concepts, the less the difference, the higher the possibility that the audience conceive higher value for that certain media or communication channel.

According to Katz, Blumler and Gurevitch's research, goals for media use can be grouped into five uses. The audience wants to:

- Be informed or educated
- Identify with characters of the situation in the media environment
- Have simple entertainment
- Enhance social interaction
- Escape from the stresses of daily life

3.3.1 What do People do with Media?

Diverging from other media effect theories that question “what does media do to people?”, UGT focuses on “what do people do with media?” It postulates that media is a highly available product and the audiences are the consumers of the same product. People seek communication to satisfy their needs, which in turn stem from social and psychological states and conditions. In other words, their needs affect their communicative behaviour.

What are the major ‘needs’ for which people seek media? We have understood that information, relaxation, companionship, diversion or escape from the needs. These needs usually have originated from social or psychological background. But each person takes the information to meet his/her own satisfaction. This satisfaction depends upon many aspects such as their social class, upbringing, the surroundings from where they hail from, and what they are already exposed to, etc.

Due to the fast pace of growth of Internet and the facility to record and store information, people have started generating their own gratification. Users are seeking cozy places to seclude themselves from the public. Various mass media are actually dividing the community on the basis of heavy users, mediocre users and non-users.

3.3.2 Types of Uses and Gratifications

Blumler has developed four categories to know why people use media:

- Diversion or escapism;
- Companionship and development of personal relationships;
- Value reinforcement and exploring personal identity; and
- Surveillance or getting information about the world.

Katz came up with a slightly different list regarding motives for media use:

- Cognitive needs,
- Affective needs, and
- Social Integrative needs

Cognitive needs: Cognitive needs means ‘People use media for acquiring knowledge, information etc.’ — audience having intellectual needs to acquire knowledge, e.g. news based and quiz programmes on TV.

Affective needs: Affective needs comprise all kinds of emotions, feelings and pleasures. People use media like television to satisfy their emotional needs. Watching serials makes the audience emotional at times.

Social Integrative needs: Social Integrative needs include the need to interact with family members, friends and relations in the society. Nowadays people socialise on social networking sites like Instagram, Facebook, Twitter etc. to satisfy their needs.

3.3.3 Assumptions of the Theory

The Uses and Gratifications Approach has five basic assumptions.

- 1) The audience is conceived as active.
- 2) In the mass communication process much initiative in linking need and gratification and media choice lies with the audience member.
- 3) The media competes with other sources of need satisfaction.
- 4) Many of the goals that media uses can be derived from data supplied by the individual audience members themselves.
- 5) Value judgments about cultural significance of mass communication should be suspended while audience operations are explored on their own terms.

3.3.4 Heuristic Approach of UGT

Katz, Blumler and Gurevitch synthesised that UGT's approach was focused on social and psychological origins of needs. UGT has gained heuristic value as it gives a kind of picture through which new ideas and theories related to media choice, consumption and impact can be viewed.

Modern application

Interactive communication: The new communication technologies are largely interactive in nature. Hence, UGT has emphasised on new models of communication. In 21st century we can see there is an increase in applicability of UGT, as there is a boom in media growth. UGT and information science go hand in hand.

Library and the UGT

Libraries are also considered as media institutions because they have the most important role in transferring the collective and historical memory of different ethnic groups and nations (Ghafari and Shaghaghi, 2010). Libraries are the storage houses and therefore they are responsible for informational interaction.

UGT and Modern Libraries

The library services have undergone a sea change after the introduction of Information Technology. New databases, e-books, e-journals have made inroads into modern libraries, have made accessibility easier. All kinds of e-resources which help in readers' satisfaction can be studied in relation to UGT.

3.3.5 Modern Applications of UGT

UGT has applications in new media as well.

Mobile phone usage: The greatest advantages of mobile phones are its nature of mobility, continuous and easy access. This has led to studies with respect to uses and gratification.

Internet: Uses and Gratification can be explored in the field of Internet. It has three main categories of gratifications: content gratification, process gratification, and social gratification.

- **Content:** Finding specific information or material, which are gratified with content
- **Process:** Users gain gratification from browsing of the Internet
- **Social:** Building social relationship, through social networks like Facebook, WhatsApp, Twitter etc.

Interactive communication is one of the most important characteristics of information and communication technology, and is emphasised in modern models of UGT. The interaction between humans and computers is an interdisciplinary research field including fields such as information science, social informatics, information retrieval, etc. In 21st century we can see there is an increase in applicability of UGT as there is a boom in media growth. “Uses and Gratification Theory” and “Knowledge and Information Science” go hand in hand.

Check Your Progress 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Mention the types of Gratification sought by the people.

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2) List the motives for media use propounded by Kartz.

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- 1) Write a note on the assumptions of Uses and Gratification Theory

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- 2) What are the four categories developed by Blumler to know why people use media?

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3.4 RELATED THEORIES

Some theories of media and communication have similar implications as that of UGT, these are Dependency theory, Social Cognitive theory and Cultivation theory. Let us briefly look at them in this section.

3.4.1 Media System Dependency Theory

Media System Dependency Theory (MSDT) is an offshoot of UGT which focuses on **goals** of audience whereas UGT focuses on **needs** of audience. MSDT states that as a person becomes increasingly dependent on media to satisfy one's needs, media will become more important in a person's life and thereby have increased influence and effects on that person. MSDT acknowledges and builds upon UGT because it is based on the assumptions that people have different uses for media that arise from their needs. You will read more about it in Unit 4 of this block.

3.4.2 Social Cognitive Theory

Social cognitive theory explains behaviour in terms of the reciprocal causation between individuals, environments, and behaviours. In relation to UGT, Social Cognitive Theory helps to bifurcate Gratification Sought (GS) from Gratification Obtained (GO) for the consumption of media. By this, one can understand the personal application of UGT instead of the assumption about a large audience of mass media. It is self-explanatory that if Gratification Obtained is greater than Gratification Sought then there will be more audience satisfaction. Audiences' Gratification Sought may not be the answer for Gratification Obtained always.

3.4.3 Cultivation Theory

This theory has been discussed in detail in Unit one in which it was explained how one cultivates the habit of viewing a medium — especially TV. While UGT focuses on goals that drive media consumption, cultivation theory is concerned with the effects of media. It is used to study violence in TV and how it impacts the minds of viewers. Under the influence of television, it is perceived that the amount of violence has gone up in society. The principle of UGT can be applied to cultivation theory cases to study why viewer would seek violent programmes. The components of this theory help to understand its usage in everyday life as well as jobs and campaigns. However, since the needs of individuals vary, why they seek media will also vary.

Littlejohn in his book, *Theories of Human Communication* argues, “The second source of dependency is social stability.” During the time of wars, Gratification Sought (GS) and Gratification Obtained (GO) become one and the same of the whole society, because audiences become more dependent on the media for a sense of stability. Not only that, one may see an increase in media usage when something important is coming up, such as General elections. Such instances naturally make viewers more dependent on the media to satisfy their curiosity.

3.4.5 Opposing Theories

Magic Bullet Theory and Two-step flow of communication are some opposing theories of UGT. You have read them in Course MJM-020 Block 1 Unit 3, here we shall briefly touch upon them to link with our discussion.

The Hypodermic Needle Model

The hypodermic needle is a model of communication which was propounded by Harold Lasswell in 1920s. It suggests that the message which originates from the media is directly targeted to the receiver and is completely accepted by him/her. This model had become almost obsolete but thanks to big data analytics-based mass customisation which has led to a modern revival of the basic idea. “Hypodermic Needle Model” uses the same idea of the “shooting” paradigm. It proposes that the media injects its messages like hypodermic needle straight into the audience, who are passive. This passive audience is immediately affected by these messages. The public essentially cannot escape from the media’s influence, and is therefore considered a “sitting duck”. However, as discussed above, the UGT theory has proved that audience is anything but passive.

The two-step flow of communication model

The credit of developing ‘The two-step flow of communication model’ goes to Sociologist Paul Lazarsfeld in the year 1944 which was elaborated by Elihu Katz and Lazarsfeld in 1955. The two-step flow of communication model discusses how mass media influences the “opinion leaders”, who pass on their opinion to a bigger population. In this way two steps are involved. Later the information flows to wider group along with the opinion of these opinion leaders and the people at the second step become “opinion followers”.

By studying these two models, one can understand messages are shot at them by the mass media and people easily accept them. The magic bullet theory or hypodermic needle theory explores the fact that media injects the information in the minds of audience as bullets.

The crux of UGT theory is that media audiences are active rather than passive. Katz and Blumler shifted their attention from media content to media audience. It is a known fact that people receive the information but they try to interpret the message according to their requirement and understanding. When a researcher takes up a study on mass communication s/he will be aware of the fact that seeking and selecting specific media will be his/her priority.

UGT compares media to a 'product'. It says audience is the users of this 'product'. The driving question of UGT is: why do people use media and what do they use them for? UGT discusses "how users deliberately choose media that will satisfy given needs and allow one to enhance knowledge, relaxation, social interactions/ companionship, diversion, or escape".

Check Your Progress 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

- 1) Differentiate between Media-system Dependency Theory and Uses and Gratification Theory.

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- 2) Explain the following concepts — Gratification Sought and Gratification Obtained.

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- 3) Write a note on Cultivation Theory.

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- 4) Discuss the theories which oppose the concept of UGT.

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3.5 LET US SUM UP

Elihu Katz and Jay Blumler developed the Uses and Gratifications Theory in 1974 which has given a different theoretical perspective on communication. The focus of this theory is on audience which forms the crux of mass communication process. According to Katz and Blumler people not only receive information, but also unconsciously attempt to make sense of the message in their own context.

The ‘uses’ approach assumes that audiences are active and willingly expose themselves to media. The term ‘gratification’ refers to the rewards and satisfaction experienced by audiences after the use of media; it helps to explain motivations behind media use and habits of media use.

While media effect theories posed the question, “what media do to people?” UGT postulates that media is a highly available product and the audiences are the consumers of the same product. The driving question of UGT is: *Why* do people use media and what do they use them for? Audiences are often formed on the basis of similarities of individual need, interest and taste. Many of these appear to have a social or psychological origin. Typical of such ‘needs’ are those for information, relaxation, companionship, diversion or ‘escape’.

We also discussed some related and opposing theories and through the discussion tried to establish the relevance of this theory. In the next unit you will study Dependency Theory which is considered an extension of the Uses and Gratification theory.

3.6 FURTHER READINGS

Denis McQuail, *McQuail’s Mass Communication Theory*, Vistaar Publications, New Delhi, Fifth edition, page-423-8.

Katz, Elihu, Jay Blumler and Michael Gurevitch. “Uses of Mass Communication by the Individual.” *Mass Communication Research: Major Issues and Future Directions*. Eds. W.P. Davidson and Fredrick Yu. New York: Praeger, 1974. page-11-35.

Andal Narayanan. *Communication Theories and Models*, Himalaya Publishing House, 2017.

Darren G. Likkeker, *Uses and Gratifications Theory*, in *Key Concepts in Political Communication*, Sage Publications, 2006.

3.7 KEY TERMS

Media choice: People have access to a wide range of mass media to choose in order to seek information, education or entertainment. The selection is made for just to relax, spend time, vent out anger or frustration, or seek some information or entertainment.

Media consumption is the sum of information and entertainment media taken in by an individual or group. It includes activities such as interacting with new media, reading books and magazines, watching television and film, and listening to radio.

Media effect is the actual force exerted by a media message, resulting in either a change or reinforcement in audience or individual beliefs. Bryant and Zillmann (1984) defined media effects as “the social, cultural, and psychological impact of communicating via mass media”.

3.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) Two communication researchers Elihu Katz and Jay Blumler are credited for developing UGT. This theory came to light in 1974 which is considered as a reaction to traditional mass communication research.
- 2) The unique feature of this theory is media audiences are active rather than passive. Besides receiving information, audience unconsciously make an attempt to grasp the sense of the message in their own context. Katz and Blumler shifted the attention to the media audience rather than media content. The theory also explains what combinations of attributes in media content lead to the satisfaction of audience member needs. UGT speaks about audience power. They have power to consume whatever they want to and they can interpret and integrate media into their own lives.
- 3) The ‘Fraction of Selection’ formula related to media was propounded by Wilbur Schramm which helps to determine which medium an individual might choose. From this the formula one can come to a conclusion that amount of gratification an individual expects to gain from the medium is directly proportional to the effort s/he has to make to seek gratification.
- 4) Abraham Maslow put forward Maslow’s hierarchy of needs. His contention was that people try to satisfy their needs based on hierarchy. Mark Levy and Sven Windahl opined that UGT is an audience-centered theory. According to West and Turner UGT has passed four developmental stages. Communication researchers accepted this only after verifying those four stages or phases.

Check Your Progress 2

- 1) Researchers have stated two different types of gratification; “content gratification” and “process gratification”. In content gratification receiving certain messages is more important, while in process gratification, participating in the “use process” is of much higher value.
- 2) The motives for media use as propounded by Katz were:
Cognitive needs, Affective needs, and Social Integrative needs.
- 3) The Uses and Gratifications Approach has five basic assumptions. The first assumption is that the audience is conceived as active. The second assumption is that in the mass communication process much initiative in linking need and gratification and media choice lies with the audience member. The third assumption is that the media competes with other sources of need satisfaction. The fourth one is that many of the goals media use can be derived from data supplied by the individual audience members.

themselves. The final assumption is that value judgments about cultural significance of mass communication should be suspended while audience operations are explored on their own terms.

- 4) The four categories developed by Blumer to know why people use media are:
 - Diversion or escapism
 - Companionship and development of personal relationships
 - Value reinforcement and exploring personal identity
 - Surveillance or getting information about the world.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) MSDT focuses on **goals** of audience whereas UGT focuses on **needs** of audience. MSDT states that as a person becomes increasingly dependent on media to satisfy his needs, media will become more important in a person's life and thereby will have increased influence and effects on that person.
- 2) Building on UGT, Social Cognitive Theory helped distinguish Gratification Sought (GS) versus Gratification Obtained (GO) stimulus for media consumption. Social cognitive theory explains behaviour in terms of the reciprocal causation between individuals, environments, and behaviours. If GO is greater than GS then there will be more audience satisfaction. Lastly, audiences' GS are not always the reality of their GO.
- 3) Cultivation theory explains how one cultivates the habit of viewing mass media especially TV. While UGT focuses on goals that drive media consumption, cultivation theory ponders upon the psychological effects of media. Cultivation theory is used to study violence in TV and how it impacts the minds of viewers. The principle of UGT can be applied to cultivation theory cases to study why viewer would seek violent programmes.
- 4) **The hypodermic needle model** is a model of communication propounded by Harold Lasswell. It suggests that the message which originates from the media is directly targeted to the receiver and completely accepted by him. Hypodermic Needle Model uses the same idea of the shooting paradigm. The public essentially cannot escape from the media's influence, and is therefore considered a sitting duck.

The two-step flow of communication model by Paul Lazarsfeld discusses how mass media influences the "opinion leaders". These opinion leaders pass on their opinion to a bigger population. Mass media are successful in passing the information to a set of people and are called opinion leaders. Later the information flows to wider group along with the opinion of these opinion leaders who become "opinion followers".

UNIT 4 DEPENDENCY THEORY

Structure

- 4.0 Introduction
- 4.1 Learning Outcomes
- 4.2 Media Dependency Theory: Concept and Nature
- 4.3 Media Contents and their Effects on Audience
 - 4.3.1 Cognitive
 - 4.3.2 Affective
 - 4.3.3 Behaviours
- 4.4 Models on Media Dependency Theory
 - 4.4.1 Levels of Message Effects
 - 4.4.2 An Integrated Approach Model on Media Effects
- 4.5 New Media and Media Dependency Theory
- 4.6 Media Dependency Theory: A Critique
- 4.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 4.8 Further Readings
- 4.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

4.0 INTRODUCTION

Mass media have emerged as dominant players in modern society. They exert influence in varying degrees on their users. The steady expansion of mass media beginning from print followed by cinema, radio, television and in recent times the convergence of different media technologies have profound influence on audience. The combination of electronic media – radio and TV has brought society further closer to information and entertainment round the clock. The average time spent on various communication media has gone up in an impressive manner over the years.

Mass media are 20th century phenomenon. Apart from their growth and expansion, the interest in their consumption patterns and their influences attracted researchers to examine their influence. These studies identified the time devoted on media, the consumption patterns, the gratifications they derived and the effects they had on their audiences. The expansion of mass media engaged audience by diverting their time and attention from other activities and reached large number of people.

Dependency Theory is an extension of Uses and Gratifications theory advocating integral relationship among audiences and media within the context of social system. The key factor is whenever certain social factors and practices are challenged, the dependency on media would increase while during peaceful time, people rely less on them. The key elements advocated in the Dependency Theory are in the context of audience, media and social system. Two eminent communication scholars Sandra Ball-Rokeach and Melvin Lawrence DeFleur proposed Dependency Theory in 1976. In the 1970s and 1980s, DeFleur continued studies on news diffusion. The research investigations undertook by DeFleur

4.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the effects of media on users in socio-cultural context;
- describe the factors that influence dependence on the media by audience;
- analyse audience-media-society relationships; and
- analyse the relevance of the Dependency Theory in the context of new social media.

4.2 MEDIA DEPENDENCY THEORY: CONCEPT AND NATURE

The steady expansion of mass media during the early part of 20th century attracted the attention of media researchers, mostly from sociology, political science, and psychology, to examine media effects. Urbanisation and migration of population compelled people to depend more on media for information and entertainment. The traditional news sources gave way for technology aided communication media. Media like radio and cinema were extensively used for the purpose of political propaganda during the two world wars. In post-war period researchers evinced keen interest in studying media effects and a new tradition of media research was born. Media intervention in modernising agriculture and health practices attracted attention of communication researchers.

In the early part of 20th century, Media established its presence in large parts of Europe and America. The researchers evolved scientific methodology to examine the effects of such powerful and pervasive media devices. Early studies advocated that mass media are very powerful in influencing the people. Later, studies with better methodological approaches proved that many intervening variables play significant role in influencing people. One such theory that advocated the influence of social, cultural and other beliefs that shape media effects is the Dependency Theory of media effects or Media Dependency Theory.

In an article published in the journal (Communication Research, 1976), both Sandra Ball-Rokeach and Melvin Lawrence DeFleur challenged the notion of all powerful effects of media. Their argument was that both “hypodermic needle” and “magic bullet” concepts of dominant media effects have failed “to support such a conceptualisation”. Earlier, media were projected as all powerful, pervasive that directly reach the audience without any hindrance. Factors such as personal beliefs, societal and cultural barriers were not considered as intervening factors for effective communication. The stimulus response probabilities ignored the complexities of human communication.

Another aspect is that of complex social system and the relationship between the individual and the society. A social institution like mass media plays a critical role in influencing people on many issues. The declining power and control of social system over individuals paved way for the commanding role of media. Studies have endorsed the premise that media play a dominant role in persuasion

of audience in adoption of messages. It is this complex relationship of variables, which requires to be examined in order to establish the dependency on media.

When the traditional society transformed into an urban and industrial mass society during 20th century, certain distinctive characteristics emerged in the process. They were influenced by factors such as “bureaucracy, contracts, migration, stratification, and the spread of innovation. It is said that all of these individual and social forces have worked to set people apart rather than bring them together” (Lowery and DeFluer, 1995).

The new impersonal society emerged because of social differentiation, erosion of social controls, and psychological alienation in urban setting which led to dependency on mass media. Aside with rapid industrialisation and urbanisation, mass media emerge as central forces disseminating information to a diverse audience. As the circulation of newspapers and magazines galloped, their influence was evident in social and cultural behaviours. Watching of films was becoming more popular. Critics accused media responsible for the decline of moral and cultural values in the society. This led to more studies aimed to examine the influence of media on their audiences.

The proponents of the Media Dependency Theory argued, “audiences frequently encounter media messages about which they have pre-established beliefs and norms that are anchored in their group associations and that filter or recreate media messages to conform to the established social realities of the audience. While such generalisations are helpful in understanding the psychological and social processes which act as constraints on media influence, the conceptualisations on which they are based may not be the best guides for studying a complex social process such as mass communication” (Lowery and DeFluer 1995).

The argument of the authors is that every individual is a member of a social group and they have pre-established norms and media messages that will be conformed as per social realities. Further, as the social structure becomes more complex, people lose contact with the system and start to rely a great deal on mass media. As powerful institutions, mass media have a dominant role not only in persuading their audiences but also in providing wide range of information. Researchers earlier advocated that media are all powerful but they ignored audience in the communication process, whereas Media Dependency Theory regards audience as an active participant.

Check Your Progress 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Why dependence theory is considered an extension of Uses and Gratification Theory?

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- 2) What factors led to the examination of the influence of media on their audiences?

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4.3 MEDIA CONTENTS AND THEIR EFFECTS ON AUDIENCE

The growth of mass communication is inextricably related to the growth of new technologies besides developments in the fields of transportation, economic advancements, increase in the leisure time and enhanced purchasing power of people. The growth of society is consistently supported by improved communication services through various media. During the first half of the 20th century, the circulation of newspapers increased voluminously across Europe, America and other parts of the world. Movies emerged as major source of entertainment.

The widespread reach and popularity of different communication media made people to depend on them for information, education and entertainment in the new urban settings. Researchers argued that the study of mass communication is based on the postulation that the media have effects on masses. Different communication scholars have categorised effects of mass media in different ways depending upon the nature and purpose of media messages.

The postulation of the dependency model is that masses are extremely dependent on media for their diverse needs. One form of dependency is that media are the major source of information. An individual had to depend on media for knowledge to act meaningfully and successfully. Media initially became an urban phenomenon as audience in urban areas have to depend on media for entertainment and relaxation.

This core concept of the Dependency Theory is that communication and society are inseparable and both are interdependent. No modern society can survive without modern media of communication.

The argument of the theory is that people depend on media for information needs in almost all fields – politics, economics, business, lifestyle, entertainment, leisure time activities etc. Thus, several factors control the degree of media dependence. Whenever there are significant transformations in society the dependence on media increases. Throughout such time the reliance on media for information, guidance and suggestions would normally go up. During more secure times, the dependency on media would usually decrease.

As mentioned, the degree of stability varies in the social system. For instance during the times of war, massive floods, disasters, earthquakes or any unnatural developments, the social system gets affected. In such circumstances, the dependency on media goes up as one would depend mainly on media for information, latest developments, precautions to be taken etc. On the other hand, the centrality of information functions varies. Media establishments with their systematic networks of information gathering systems attempt to supply updated developments. If print media offer detailed information on any crisis, television would ensure round the clock updates with both audio and video inputs. Similarly, radio would also offer latest information in more convenient manner as it is mobile. Of course, the latest apps through networks could also provide latest developments through smart phones. Therefore, each medium attempts to fulfil the information needs of the users depending on their needs. As pointed out by the proponents of the theory, information functions of each medium vary in a media system.

On the other hand, the degree of dependence of the audience varies both in social and media systems. If the social system is stable, the dependence on media may be somewhat less and in unstable situation the dependence on media system would automatically go up.

Ball-Rokeach et al. (1976) believed that the dependency on media lead to various cognitive, affective and behavioural effects. The theory explores the relationship between media, society and the audiences. It argues that an individual living in urban areas is more dependent on media for information as it affects their day to day living than those settled in suburban or rural area.

The dependency model proposed by authors attaches importance to several cognitive, affective, and behavioural effects on the audience. Media messages are constant and pervasive in contemporary context. They persistently exert influence on their audience. However, it should be understood that not all messages are accepted by audience as they are competent enough to select according to their needs and interests.

4.3.1 Cognitive

We are bombarded with information by the mass media. We live in information age and an information-centric society. We are flooded with information. Media messages contain an overload of information every day. Messages that originate through newspapers, periodicals, books, websites, radio and television are a valuable source of knowledge, which influence thinking process resulting in gaining knowledge. In the process, information is turned into knowledge through the thought process. As a thinking being, man can evaluate, compare and infer meanings and decide on its uses. Based on one's educational background and mental abilities, a person can draw meanings from media messages. Media help to update knowledge and present different perspectives on significant issues helping audience to draw conclusions. Individuals also have the capacity to think even beyond media messages. This process of evaluating messages is termed as cognitive messages.

Media are windows to the world. They disseminate information about the external world. This helps people to expand their knowledge at global level which also effect their belief systems. We know so much about complex issues like nuclear

arms, global warming, atmospheric pollution, poverty, gender discriminations, and exploitations without being experts on these subjects. We have gained knowledge from media on worldly issues. Whenever some issues crop up at global or regional levels, media clarify on existing values and conflicts and offer information. On prominent issues related to human rights or child rights to education or right to information, media offer an opportunity to public to voice their concerns. Therefore, the value conflicts are recognised by the public and issues get public approval or disapproval. More importantly, media assist in clarifying certain issues and removes ambiguity.

When the level of uncertainty is very high because of inadequate information, audience will be inclined to look up to media to get more insight on the issue. It is to be noted that ambiguity also creates stress in the minds of audience. As pointed out earlier, media would identify some burning issues and make their audience deliberate on them. Public are invited to give suggestions on solving issues. The agenda setting of media on certain situations, if logically created, would make the audience rely more on media for guidance and clarifications. The exposure to media invariably helps to form attitudes on public issues. They may include corrupt practices in politics, gender issues, representation of women in legislatures etc. Most of the times, media draw attention to these issues and create opportunities to deliberate and generate proper understanding of an issue.

People generally depend on news updates to make sure that their life is secure and society is peaceful. Media campaigns on burning issues may prompt some members of the audience to think more realistically and mobilise support for the cause.

4.3.2 Affective

Human beings react to the changes that take place around them, be it happiness, fear, anger or laughter. The media can trigger emotions, especially fear, lust, anger, and laughter. The media also offer their users with lots of opportunities to manage the emotions and moods. People are curious and eager to know what is happening around them. That is one major reason why we access media. We also react to what we watch on TV, movies or Internet. Listening to music can change your mood and help you relax. We watch TV shows to relax and this may reduce routine stress.

Most of the contents both in print and electronic media aim at making you respond to the developments either in positive or negative ways. This is called as affect stimulated by media contents. For instance, prolonged exposure to certain contents might make audience to develop desensitisation. One may not be keen to help reduce such incidents and might dismiss them as routines. Some programmes may make you avoid some places or people as they have been shown in a negative manner. If a group of people or places are constantly shown in a negative way, they may develop a sense of alienation.

4.3.3 Behaviours

Behaviour is defined as response to a particular situation. It is an overt action of an individual. One could be aggressive, polite, passive, cunning, social, helpful or considerate. The list is endless. They can be grouped based on professions, occasions, timings etc. The continuous exposure to media would certainly alter

the behaviours. Media may change the opinions, beliefs of the mass audience. Advertising messages continuously try to change the consumer behaviours. Lifestyle contents in media may affect our dressing, hairstyle etc. Political messages may change party leanings. Cinema exerts a great deal of influence on lifestyle. Some media content might induce aggressive behaviours. As audiences are constantly exposed to media content, their behavioural patterns are bound to be influenced.

Behavioural effects normally result in some kind of action. Many a time, media content induces people to imitate certain actions or repeat them. There is likelihood that one may not repeat such actions because of exposure to media. This activation and deactivation of actions is a continuous process determining human behaviour.

4.4 MODELS ON MEDIA DEPENDENCY THEORY

Over the years, the media outlets began offering specialised contents to catch the attention of the audience. Publications devoted to sports, cinema, women, business, music etc. flourished. Same trend emerged in the field of TV and radio also. Research into the areas of attitudinal changes revealed that even though same messages are delivered to the audience, the reception and effect is not uniform among the audience. Each user of medium perceived common messages interpreted and understood differently. This was a turning point in the history of communication research. The concepts like selective exposure, attention, perception and retention noted that audience are heterogeneous in nature, their media needs are different and they are selective in choosing the messages. Studies have disproved that media have uniform effects. Thus, different audience react differently to media messages based on their socio-economic backgrounds. The notion that media are powerful and would have uniform effect on their audience is proved wrong.

Based on this assumption, the authors of Dependency Theory proposed that the specific media content selected by the audience assume significance. The dependency on media is subjected to several individual considerations and requirements, which would influence exposure. Depending on individual requirements, the dependency is activated during exposure. If the contents do not suit the wants, s/he would exit. In case the greater degree of intensity of relevance, the cognitive arousal will increase and that would influence thought process. This process would increase in case the involvement in information processing is very intensive. The authors argue that the greater the involvement, greater the probability of cognitive, affective and behavioural effects from media. Therefore, the relationship between media and an individual depends on mutual requirements.

From above analysis it is clear that mass media are not all powerful and their contents would have no uniform effects on their audience. A number of intervening variables come in the way of media contents and the way their audience perceives. Audience tend to select only those messages which are in accordance with their beliefs and attitudes and ignore other contents. Thus, the identical media messages might influence heterogeneous audience differently based on their socio-economic background, culture and social relationships.

The model proposed by the authors of the Dependency Media Theory illustrates how media messages operate in different socio, economic and political systems. Every individual is part of a socio-economic and political system. Similarly, media systems also operate in such a system.

Activity-1

Refer some research articles on web and in your University library. You could also log on to *Shodhganga* and refer PhD theses to understand the significance of Media Dependency theory and its applications in research. Analyse how and why people rely on media for their news, entertainment and informational requirements.

4.4.1 Levels of Message Effects

The process of how media contents affect is grouped into three different levels known as Micro, Meso and Macro levels. These levels are related to each other and also to the individual needs. An individual is also linked to interpersonal networks and his/her relationships are based on individual and personal characteristics, which would influence media system dependency relations. They are affected at three levels.

An influence at **Micro** level is based on their individual characteristics and requirements between individuals and media. The micro level dependency starts with an assessment of the type of motivation that brings individuals to use the media. Goals are preferred to needs to conceptualise the motivations that affect media behaviour. They are the key aspect of individual motivation. Here goals and needs are highlighted by the proponents of the Dependency Theory. Needs may involve both rational and irrational motives while goals imply a problem-solving motivation more suitable to a theory of media behaviour based upon the dependency relation.

The three motivational goals identified are understanding, orientation and play. Understanding such needs requires appreciative of themselves and the world around them. One would also be capable to interact successfully with others in order to direct personal actions. As a member a group, one should be capable of understanding one's need to learn the roles and norms and demonstrate them in some occasions.

At **Meso** level, interpersonal networks of an individual will affect the way messages are received and verified. However, the interpersonal networks would be limited to a community or an organisation. The group interactions and behaviours have a major role in influencing information seeking behaviours of an individual.

At **Macro** level, social environment which constitutes economic and political systems of a nation would affect the way an individual seeks and procures information and that depends on media system. The Dependency Theory argues that these interrelationships influence what kinds of media products are disseminated to the public for consumption, and the range of possible uses people have for media. Media systems cannot operate in isolation. They are part of social, political and economic systems and are mutually dependent and supportive. The goals and functioning of mass media are influenced by several factors. These

factors would also influence the messages the audience consume which in turn affect the audience. The extent to which audience depend on media to fulfil individual needs would depend on the efficiency of media and their commitment. Media should be allowed to function in a free environment keeping in mind the larger interests of the society in which they function. The interdependencies of different systems, which operate in a society, become crucial for the good of a society.

4.4.2 An Integrated Approach on Media Effects

In the earlier phase of communication research, media were assumed very powerful and were regarded as magic bullets fired from media gun to the viewer's heads. The researchers argued that media injects their messages straight into the passive audience. They concluded that public could not escape from the media's influence. However, over the years through adopting newer and refined research procedures, they concluded that several intervening variables are responsible for causing impact on people. The researchers observed that mass media are not the only causes for any change in the society as individuals are part of different socio-cultural groups with strong beliefs in value systems. Research verification and judgments have led to the understanding that specifics of social structure and social institutions intervene powerfully in the process of imitation and diffusion of information.

The integrated model proposed by the proponents of the media Dependency Theory identifies a large number of factors which operate among society, media and media messages. Any social system is interdependent on media and it needs to maintain relations. The cultural dynamics and the structure of the society continuously interact with media. The dynamics of the society are characterised by consensus or conflicts on certain issues.

Media institutions on the other hand are privately owned and have their own policies. Their survival depends on the resources they generate primarily through advertisements and subscription. The resource generation of media institutions would influence the quality of services they offer. In reality, the support from advertisers and from establishments is central for their effective functioning. The economic stability of such institutions will affect the quality of information delivery functions. The known and covert objectives of owners largely affect their functioning. The proponents of this theory observed that mass media do have important consequences for individuals, institutions, society and culture. The power of the mass media need to be viewed as to how effectively they can and do achieve objectives over others at the will of those who direct, own or control them or who use them as channels for messages. The ownership aspects of mass media assume significance.

Media messages are obviously directed to their audience. The realities are seen through media persons, constructed and delivered to their audiences. People depend on such information for their cognitive, affective and behavioural alterations.

Check Your Progress 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Explain in brief the following effects on the audience:

a) Cognitive

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b) Affective

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c) Behavioural

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4.5 NEW MEDIA AND MEDIA DEPENDENCY THEORY

A new dimension to mass communication is added with the emergence of social media. The computer based network systems brought in advanced connectivity through emails, blogs, websites, and online contents. Further developments in communication convergence technologies heralded a new era in human communication history. Network based Facebook, Twitter, WhatsApp YouTube, Tumblr, Instagram, LinkedIn, Snapchat and other sites and a host of new services to share and interact on online are redefining the way we communicate. These

new developments are putting the existing theories into re-examination of their relevance. Media Dependency Theory cannot be an exception.

The modern society is increasingly experiencing a mediated world rather than reality itself. The images are based on media creation of social reality. The manifestation of computer-mediated communication has altered substantially the media ecology. The view of the world now is limited to the contact with mediated representations of a complex physical and social world. Most of the social and psychological needs are getting satisfied through exposure to mass media.

New technologies offer users with a wider range of source selection and channels of information. Users are becoming highly selective as many options are available online. Electronic advances could make public consultation and participation wider, easier and more diverse, provide new opportunities, which could both focus and diversify the information, people receive and obtain for themselves.

The Internet is at the centre of a new media ecosystem that has united traditional media such as print and broadcast with modern media. The computer networks supported by communication satellites converged and offered a host of services at affordable cost. For instance, any computer or a smart phone could combine images, text, animated images, and moving pictures in portable instruments which could be accessed anywhere in real time. Distance is no more a barrier. Interactions, information retrieval, and exchange among individuals and groups are possible round the clock without any frontier restrictions.

The individual dependency relations with media have undergone significant changes over the past few decades. The unique content available through participatory usage has been massive and stunning. The cognitive process of mediating with new media technologies is characterised as new media dependency. The online content, which is easily available and shared, has opened a new chapter in communication. The social media domain is expanding fast to share more and more information. Both old and young alike have taken into new media. Hitherto, the dependence on media for news and opinions of the audience was almost one sided. The access to mass media for news, analytical information and access to documents has been almost instantaneous. The access is global, choices are abundant and it is truly a global village as stories could be created and shared publicly.

Social media have gained the ability to move across levels defined as micro, meso and macro levels without any borders. They have provided a framework for multiple relationships in which information flows. Social media played a major role in the Arab uprisings. Core group of activists and civil society leaders who succeeded in overthrowing the government in Egypt, and several Arab countries formed online networks. New media have facilitated public participation in content generation.

Activity-2

Interact with a small group of boys and girls and ask them what they do with social media like Facebook, YouTube, Twitter, LinkedIn so on. Find out how youngsters are depending on social media to meet their needs and interests.

4.6 MEDIA DEPENDENCY THEORY: A CRITIQUE

Media Dependency Theory is one of the first theories, which regard audience as an active part in communication process. The Dependency Theory is an extension of the theory of Uses and Gratification. Dependency Theory proposes an integral relationship among audiences, media and the larger social system. The premise is that you depend on media information to meet certain needs and to achieve certain goals. One may not depend on all media equally. The dependence is more on media that meet a number of needs than on media that provide just a few. It is also influenced by social stability. Individuals' needs, motives, and uses of media are dependent on outside factors that may not be in the individuals' control. The more alternatives an individual has for gratifying needs, the less dependent s/he will become on any single medium.

The Media Dependency Theory recognised active role of the audience in the mediated world of mass communication. It recognised the fact that mass media are not all powerful in influencing people. There are number of dominant variables that affect the thought process. The observations of Joseph T Klapper that mass communication does not ordinarily serve as a necessary and sufficient cause of audience effects, but rather functions through a nexus of mediating factors, holds good.

Several scholars argue that Media Dependency Theory is often difficult to empirically verify and also lacks power in explaining long-term effects. With the emergence of new media technologies, the media ecology scene is undergoing significant changes in the last few decades. The globalised world depends on globalised media systems and networks. Both materials and ideas play a major role in the globalisation process. People are more dependent on social media to fulfil their cognitive, affective, personal and social needs.

Scholars argue that theories are not made to prove true or false. Their usage for the advancement of knowledge and to explain and predict phenomena are more important and relevant. In this context, Media Dependence Theory is still relevant for the study of media effects. The Dependency Theory seems to be logic, consistent and simple. A large number of research studies continue to use the framework of this theory in their scholarly works.

A theory is logical view of phenomena by indicating relations among variables. This would help in dissecting and predicting a phenomenon. Anderson (2012) stated that "all research problems are embedded in some theory whether explicitly stated or not. Theory develops on the foundation of assumptions or irreducible axiomatic beliefs. Theory starts when we assemble a more or less coherent base to consider the implications in some domain". In this context, the relevance of Media Dependency Theory has a major role to play even in the new media ecology.

Activity-3

Select a group of people like homemakers, young boys or girls and interact with them as to what type of programmes they watch on television and why. Do they get influenced by media, do they imitate what they watch on TV like mannerisms, gestures, and dresses, or does TV influence their opinion on politics etc. Analyse your findings in the framework of Media Dependency Theory.

Check Your Progress 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is the main critique of Dependency Theory?

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2) What is the defence of this criticism by scholars?

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4.7 LET US SUM UP

In this unit we undertook a detailed analysis on the importance of Media Dependency Theory. Earlier researchers assumed that mass media are extremely influential. Over the years, systematic and elaborated studies applying rigorous research methods found that various other factors such as culture, belief systems, socio-economic factors also play a crucial role. It is proved that audience depend on media but perceive what they want to see and retain only what is liked and needed owing to socio-cultural factors. The Uses and Gratifications theory looked into what people do with media than what media do to people.

The Media Dependency Theory examined society, media, and their messages in the context of their effects. The proponents of the theory attributed that the structure of the society, social systems and dynamics play a significant role in relation to media and media messages. They stated that dependence on media would be more during the times of crisis, disasters, wars, political upheavals etc. In normal periods, audience would choose any channel of their choice. The Media Dependency Theory strongly advocates that it is not just mere mass media, but there are other variables, which would have effects on the audience.

4.8 FURTHER READINGS

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4.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

- 1) The dependency theory advocated integral relationship among audiences and media within the context of social system. Whenever certain social factors and practices are challenged, the dependency on media would increase and during the peaceful time, they degree of dependence may go down. The key elements advocated in the Dependency theory are in the context of audience-media and social system this is why it is considered as an extension of Uses and Gratifications theory.
- 2) The emergence of a new impersonal society, rapid industrialisation and urbanisation led to social differentiation and erosion of social controls. Mass media emerged as important force for disseminating information to a diverse audience. The increased popularity of newspapers, magazines and films led to the examination of the influence of media on social and cultural behaviours.

Check Your Progress 2

a) Cognitive

Media messages contain an overload of information every day. Messages that originate through print media such as newspapers, periodicals, books, websites radio and TV programmes are a valuable source of knowledge, which influences thinking process resulting in gaining knowledge.

b) Affective

Human beings react to the changes that take place around them, be it happiness, fear, anger or laughter - known as emotions and moods. Media can trigger emotions, especially fear, lust, anger, and laughter. The media also offer their users with lots of opportunities to manage their moods. Most of the contents both in print and electronic media aim at making you respond to the developments both in positive and negative ways. This is known as affect stimulated by media contents.

c) Behavioural

Behaviour is defined as response to a particular situation. It is an overt action of an individual. One could be aggressive, polite, passive, cunning, social, helpful or considerate, and so on. Behavioural effects normally result in some kind of action. Many a time media content induces people to imitate

certain actions or repeat them. There is likelihood that one may not repeat such actions because of exposure to media. This activation and deactivation of actions is a continuous process determining human behaviour.

Check Your Progress 3

- 1) The main criticism of Media Dependency Theory is that it is often difficult to empirically verify. Moreover, the media landscape is undergoing significant changes in the last few decades due to globalisation and the emergence of new media technologies and the theory lacks power in explaining their long-term effects.
- 2) Scholars argue that Media Dependence Theory is still relevant for the study of media effects as theories are not made to prove true or false. Their usage for the advancement of knowledge and to explain and predict phenomena are more important and relevant. The Dependency Theory is logic, consistent and the framework is used in a large number of research studies.



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